A commentary on the essence of

The Jewel Ornament of Liberation

of Dharma Lord Gampopa

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Ch. 4 Impermanence

0. All composite phenomena are impermanent

Meditation on Impermanence as great healing

1. I will read a few lines and explain, and then you can read more details. *Of these, the first instruction is the meditation on impermanence as the antidote/remedy to attachment to this life.*

2. *"All composite phenomena…"*
   Composite phenomena are produced through many causes and conditions, which then produce one.
   Just like a writing pen: the pen is composed of, or a product of, many causes and conditions.
   So Buddha said all those are impermanent.

3. *"O monks, all composite phenomena are impermanent."*
   Monks and nuns need a lot of reminders of impermanence.
   Wearing Dharma robes without contemplating impermanence is not so good.
   So then, mental afflictions come; attachment comes, and the fighting.

4. So, to hundreds of thousands of monks and nuns the Buddha said: *"O monks and nuns, all composite phenomena are impermanent."*
   Then all the bubbling of the mind just slows down.
   All the attachment around there is lessened, and the mind becomes more peaceful, physically more peaceful.
   We just reflect and meditate on this.

5. Just meditate on it.
   For example,
   when there's deep suffering, meditate on impermanence.
   Take a deep breath:
   everything is impermanent.
   When you are taking all your attention to the suffering, this helps to release the suffering,
   "Oh, the suffering is not permanent, it will change."
   Meditate.

6. When strong anger arises, meditate on impermanence.
   The person to whom you have the anger is impermanent. So,
   "Why are you so vicious about your anger to that person?"
   It helps to release that power.

7. It's very easy to do but it's
very important to do off and on.
Just sit, just take a
deep breath and meditate.
When you are next to a tree,
the wind blows,
the tree moves making noise;
meditate, "Oh, this is
impermanent, it's changing,
everything has this nature."
While I talk about impermanence,
please meditate on this.

8. Meditating on impermanence
is great healing.
It's not a negative thing.
Whether we contemplate
on impermanence or not,
we are impermanent anyway.

9. Those who don't believe in
impermanence are impermanent
anyway. No choice.
Sometimes some people say,
"Impermanence is such
a negative thought,
let us have a more positive…
don't think about impermanence."
But it is impermanent anyway.

10. Now in the world,
wives and husbands, when they
disagree so much, they divorce —
one, two, three times.
And there are some who have
very good relationships,
so peaceful, so grateful — they
spend their whole life together.
But at the end of their life
there's so much suffering:
"I lost my husband/wife.
We were so good together,
we loved each other so much.
I miss him/her so much."
And the pain is so much,
in the mind, in the heart.

11. Now I'm getting old,
and so are many of my friends.
Sometimes they are writing "Can
you say prayers so that in
their next life they can meet
my husband, my wife again."
What should I say, really?
Attachment is that pain,
so much.

12. Impermanence is not
about being careless.
As I mentioned, you care for
each other, you help each other,
you support each other — but
look at impermanence, practice.
When you have impermanence,
you are prepared, and also you
can live more peacefully.

13. So, “You are impermanent, I’m impermanent, let’s live peacefully, without fighting.” Then you can get so much benefit, and remind each other of Dharma practice: “It’s not just only this life — let’s practice for enlightenment, for buddhahood, for the benefit of all sentient beings.” Like that, impermanence has such powerful instructions.

0. The end of accumulation is dispersion

Instead, practice gratitude

1. Now, there are four points which are very important. In what way are they impermanent? *“The end of accumulation is dispersion or exhaustion.”* This is the first point.

2. You accumulate wealth, but at the end it exhausts — disperses, or reduces. There are some very rich people who at the end of their life have nothing: exhausted, consumed. If you read the history of the past you’ll see.

3. Nowadays you see in some countries, when they become the leader of the country, with greed they accumulate so much. They have so much, but the people don’t have anything. So now people are protesting — it’s a cause of suffering — so they have to run away. Then, what’s the benefit to accumulate all this? Look at this.

4. As I mentioned the other day, when you get a bowl of porridge or a few pieces of bread, you appreciate, you rejoice: “It’s because of all the other people’s support that I got this. I’m so fortunate. I appreciate, I rejoice, I’m content with that.” And there’s great peace, joy, because you appreciate. “So I’m so grateful.”

5. We live moment to moment. We plan for the next day, we plan for next week, next month, next year. But who knows? It’s indefinite. But we have now, and now is the time to practice Dharma.

6. Now is the time we have total freedom about how to manage our mind. So impermanence practice is such a powerful way to manage our mind, moment to moment.

0. The end of construction is falling

Meditate "All constructions are like this"

1. Then, *"The end of construction is falling."* This is the second point.

2. You built buildings, built roads, built airplanes, railways, all the cars, tractors — all this, after some time you see it is falling, falling into parts. You constantly have to repair all of them.

3. Just for Buddhists, if anybody went to India… Once Buddhists became so powerful. You could go to the Bodhgaya, Nalanda area, Kushinagar, Lumbini: so many monasteries were built, hundreds and thousands of monks and nuns were there, but now you just see ruins.

4. So look at this, remind yourself, meditate on all of this.

0. The end of meeting is separating

Prepare, and handle it wisely, carefully

1. Then, *"The end of meeting is separating."* This is the third point.

2. So all meetings in life are like that. Husband and wife, we meet, we met; or children are born, they meet their parents, parents meet their children. But at the end we separate. Maybe we stay together 50 years, 60 years, 70 years, even 100 years, but then one day we have to separate. Look at this.

3. So, as I mentioned earlier, it's about preparation so there is not so much pain. When we prepare, meditate on this, then when it actually happens there's not so much pain. Otherwise there's such great pain, desperate — you cry, and sometimes there is suicide.

4. So Buddha taught "This is the reality nature but you can handle it wisely, carefully." Instead, you should get so much benefit from this. Instead of going through so much suffering, try to get benefit from this.

5. So we need courage, wisdom, just like earlier I mentioned.

0. The end of life is death

Liberation is in your hand

1. Then, *"The end of life is death."* This is the fourth point.

2. When we are born,
it means one day we'll die.
Mostly we know we'll die one
day — we know it, because
history can tell us there's
no one who lived forever.
Even if they live 100 years,
120 years, still they will die
one day. It's clear, obvious.
But when we are not prepared,
then the suffering is so much.
So we don't need suffering.

3. Without preparation,
at that time we call this guru,
that lama, that great teacher:
"Can you help me? I'm going
through so much suffering."
Then what can the guru tell,
what can the lama tell,
you know?

4. So the Buddha directly
talked to his followers:
"I can give you all the
instructions, all the methods" —
as here Gampopa is teaching us —
"but you have to apply yourself.
Liberation is in your hand."
So how grateful!

5. Buddha was not telling,
"Bring all your offerings to me,
I will do everything for you."
Buddha was telling,
"You have to sustain your life,
you meditate your life.
Live in the middle way,
not too much, not too little."
Everything in the middle,
that way is manageable:
you can manage your life.
When there's too much,
you cannot manage.

6. I saw there are some people
who have a lot of collections,
and they're suffering so much.
They don't know what
to do with those;
they can't get rid of them,
and they cannot keep them all.
So Buddha is teaching us how
to manage our life.

7. And then there comes the peace,
there comes the joy,
peace and happiness.
And then it is not just only
for this life, but for the
next life and enlightenment,
if one can manage.

0. These four include all impermanence

The mind is the most important

1. So, these four: firstly, please contemplate these four, they are very important. These four include all the composite phenomena — the accumulation, the constructions, the meeting and the life. Within these four all the impermanence is included.

2. So reflect on these four subjects: first memorize them, and reflect on these, and then meditate on impermanence.

3. All the accumulations, at the end they will exhaust, they will disperse. And all the constructions, no matter how concrete you build, after some time they will fall — like airplanes, trains, roads, buildings.

4. And you see, all we met, like in a meeting hall: hundreds of people you meet, and after some time everything is gone, by themselves, separated. Look at this — everything is just illusory nature. At one point there are hundreds of thousands of people in a big hall; after a few hours they are all gone, and the hall becomes empty. That's called illusion. If that is not an illusion, then what is an illusion?

5. Reflect on this. In the morning, a beautiful flower; in the afternoon it fades, it decays. So, like that.

6. So meditate on this. Appreciate the opportunity you have, appreciate the health you have: "I must use it to practice Dharma." Dharma practice means to improve our mental quality. The mind is the most important, as you can see.

7. Buddha taught the complete nature of the mind — nothing is missing to achieve complete enlightenment — the complete nature of the mind in the relative state and in the absolute state.

8. The modern scientists, neurologists, they are working so hard to see the mind, using all the telescopes, all the machines. They cut the brain into many pieces — "Where's the mind?" — but they cannot find it. They have to meditate themselves: they have to get good shamatha and special insight. Through these two methods they can understand the mind. Otherwise, through a machine they cannot see, because machines are matter, substance, and the mind is consciousness — it's not matter.

9. We know we have a mind, but we don't know how it is, because our attention is completely, always on the outside, not inside.

10. I wrote one book, "Samsara & Nirvana: two sides of the same hand". It is about how one side of the mind works, and the other side, how to see the non-duality. It's a very complex subject. So this is always to improve our mind, to see the advance of the mind, how to relax the mind.

11. Finally, I just want you to reflect on these four topics. First, this quotation — the Buddha said, *"O nuns and monks, all composite phenomena are impermanent."* It's very simple, but a very powerful message. And then next, those four topics. Please reflect on this.

I. - II.A Gross, subtle and very subtle impermanence

How much we are deluded

1. Then next, the summary of this impermanence: *"classification, method of meditation and beneficial effects of meditation."* These three comprise all the contemplation on impermanence, and these are very nicely described in this book. You just read it and it's not so difficult to understand.

2. So first is outer phenomena, inner phenomena. Outer is the whole universe: the gross impermanence, and then subtle impermanence, and very subtle impermanence. So these are examples on how to practice impermanence, step by step.

3. First, when you look at the mountains, like the rocky mountains, all this looks very solid. They are like a rock — so silent, unmovable — but they are impermanent. So meditate on that.

4. Then, after the gross impermanence, go to a little more subtle impermanence. See the four seasons, how the four seasons change. And then day and night: just see how everything is impermanent.

5. Then very subtle impermanence:
like the running of the river.
The continuation,
the running of the river,
is so continuously changing.
I don't realize how it is
changing, but it's changing so…
every second it is changing.

6. So we are deluded to perceive
that, because the continuity
is similar. That's why I say,
"I saw this river last year",
"I saw this river yesterday."
Actually, it's gone;
it's gone to the ocean.
What I'm seeing now, today,
is different from yesterday.
But I am deluded to see
the same river that I
saw yesterday and today.
So how deluded we are, you see?

7. So the river is
constantly changing.
Past is past, future is future,
but, like the river,
this present moment is changing.
That means that nature itself
is emptiness. So through
this practice, meditation,
from the impermanence you
can realize the emptiness.
So meditate on this.

8. And that's your mind — how your
mind can change and can improve.
For example, "Oh yes, my
friend — first I like so much,
and by just one instance,
then I say I don't like you."
Everything is kind of delicate,
changing. So meditate on this.

9. So that is the Mahamudra,
Dzogchen. That's very profound,
but because our gross mind finds
it difficult to comprehend,
we don't see it that way.
That's the impermanence of the
outer phenomena.

II.B Impermanence of the Inner Sentient Beings

Preparing to die peacefully, joyfully

1. Then inner phenomena:
sentient beings — everyone
in the world is impermanent.
Here it is called *"impermanence of others"*: all sentient
beings are impermanent.
And *"impermanence of oneself"*:
I also am in the state
of impermanence;
I am also changing.

2. Just reflect, take a deep breath
and relax: "From last year to
this year, I changed one year —
my life is shorter.
From last month, one month
is gone. From last week,
one week is gone.
From yesterday, one day is gone.
Now, from this morning,
one hour, two hours are gone."
Just meditate like that:
"That's my nature.
I'm changing every second."

3. So, that means,
impermanence means, no essence.
There's no essence.
You look at a beautiful
flower, so precious,
but that very beautiful
flower fades in one second.
So there's no essence;
it's changing.
You can see that through your
wisdom, special insight:
everything is changing,
everything is like a bubble,
everything is like a mirage.

4. So look at this,
meditate and calm your mind.
Bring your mind to the right
place, relax there, meditate.
Then everything starts to
be natural.

5. So this way we are
preparing for our death —
to die peacefully, joyfully.
Sometimes we put so much
attention on the bardo,
like the instructions on
what to do in the bardo,
phowa and this and that.
But if you are not prepared,
these instructions will do
nothing. So we have to prepare
step by step.

6. So here it tells us
about how we will die.
Sometimes death is threatening:
"You will die."
"Oh, I don't like that.
This is scary."
But we have to prepare,
prepare peacefully, joyfully,
through the Dharma practice.

7. Gampopa explains, *To meditate
on death, one should think:
"I myself cannot stay long
in this world and will have
to leave for the next life."*
So I have to prepare.

8. But what does preparing
for death mean?
Contemplate this way:
*Meditate on the characteristic
of death by contemplating,
"my life ends…"* At the time
of death, what happens?
This breath that I'm breathing
will cease to exist, and *"…
this body becomes a corpse."*
When the breath stops,
this way a person is dead.
And this mind leaves the body —
*"…and this mind has to
wander in different places."*
— dependent on the conditions.
So meditate on this.

9. So at that time,
instead of my mind following the
wrong direction — attachment,
aversion — my mind maintains
in the bodhicitta, my mind
maintains within the Mahamudra.
My mind maintains in the loving
kindness: “May every sentient
being have peace and happiness.
May every sentient being
be free from suffering.
May they all achieve
enlightenment, including
people who don’t like me.”
Everything is illusory nature.
There’s nothing to attach…
just a manifestation of
causes and conditions.
I maintain my mind in the peace.
This is so precious.
This is the best way of the
transition of our death, and so
impermanence is so precious.

10. So this is the practice
of impermanence,
how to practice impermanence.
Reflect your mind in this way.

II.B Utilize this body to benefit others

The power of contemplating impermanence

1. There are details on the
impermanence of sentient beings;
you can read those.
I don’t have to go
through all the steps.
But there’s one point:
“I cherish this body so much.
I sacrifice, I sacrifice
many things for this body,
but at the time of death I have
to leave this body behind.
All the negative karma that
I have created to protect
this body — when I die
the body is left behind,
but the karma that I made I have
to carry life after life.”

2. So instead of cherishing this
body, attached to this body,
utilize this body to
practice bodhicitta,
to practice the Dharma,
and utilize this body to benefit
others — how to help others.
So these are some important
points you can pick up from
this impermanence.

3. Then you'll be so happy to help others, to benefit others.
   We all are impermanent;
   we will change,
   so relax the mind in that.
   Instead of being upset,
   being angry, just relax the
   mind and meditate on this,
   and then do all the things that
   you can do to help others,
   to help yourself,
   to meditate yourself.

4. This way, look at our mind.
   As mentioned,
   the habitual tendencies,
   the inveterate propensities,
   look so concrete, so stubborn,
   but their nature is impermanent,
   their nature is emptiness.
   So if I make the effort,
   I can do it, because they are
   impermanent.

5. No matter how much I am so
   habituated in this samsaric
   habit, still their nature
   is impermanent, emptiness.
   So I can make it happen,
   to purify them.
   So this is the power of
   contemplating impermanence.

6. Relax, meditate.
   This way you always feel
   so light, not much burden.
   Release all your burden
   and practice the Dharma,
   and especially bodhicitta.

7. Instead of only focusing on this
   life, focus on enlightenment,
   on buddhahood.
   So, "I should use this body not
   only for this life's enjoyment,
   but I should use this body
   for the enlightenment of all
   sentient beings."

8. So for this, reading the life
   stories of great masters is
   so precious, how they have
   practiced, how they have
   benefited sentient beings.

9. So, as mentioned, it's not
   just a religious training.
   Our inveterate mind of
   habits is so arrogant.
   So the training of the mind
   is so that we can break
   through this arrogant mind,
   make the mind flexible,
   make the mind like space.

10. Impermanence has a lot
    of subjects there;
    you can read them, and as I
    mentioned, it's so precious.
    Then look at this:
    whenever you see people dying,
    reflect, "One day it will
    also happen to me like this.
    I must practice Dharma."
    Just remind yourself of this,
    again and again.

III. The beneficial effects

Release attachment and hatred

1. So, through these practices of impermanence, then come the beneficial effects. Here: *"Awareness of the impermanence of all composite phenomena leads one to release attachment to this life."*

2. When we repeat this, meditate on this, then our attachment, our pernicious attachment, is purified, and the mind becomes spacious. And then that spacious mind has such a great opportunity to develop bodhicitta.

3. *"Further, it nourishes faith,"* When you look at the impermanence of all phenomena, then our faith, our interest in enlightenment, becomes strong — not only for this life, but for enlightenment, to help others.

4. *"…it supports perseverance,"*: life is impermanent, "I must practice. I cannot stay lazy." In the morning you get up and do practice; in the evening you practice; during the daytime, do meditation practice as often as possible — because everything is impermanent.

5. Even if you just watch the breath, relax, meditate, and contemplate everyone's desire for peace and happiness — because of that, reflect on the loving kindness, compassion.

6. *"… and it quickly frees one from attachment and hatred."* So through this mindfulness of impermanence, it helps us to release our attachment, our aversion, hatred. As earlier I mentioned, when this attachment and hatred are purified that's the real peace that can be experienced in the mind.

7. There are some individuals… very vicious to you. So if we are kind of vicious back to that individual, then our hatred mind brings a lot of pain, suffering: "How can I get rid of this person? How should I respond to this?"

8. Instead, reflect: this person is so stupid, ignorant, doesn't know how to handle, doesn't know how to bring peace and happiness; he or she is suffering so much. All these are impermanent, moment to moment changing, and that person doesn't know how to do that.

9. So you reflect about the suffering of that person and develop love and compassion, and all your mental suffering just disappears. That disappearing of that suffering is called the practice of emptiness.

III. Equal nature of all phenomena

Don't treat impermanence as some small subject

1. There's no "big thing" about emptiness. Everything stands within the emptiness. Everything functions within emptiness, manifests from emptiness, dissolves into emptiness. If you know this, are aware of this, then you can relax, meditate there, and appreciate Dharma.

2. That's why the relative state and the absolute are non-duality. We don't make them non-duality, but their nature is within the non-duality. We make duality, and then we suffer. But if we have the wisdom to see how they function within the non-duality, the peace is in our hand.

3. So this is the wisdom of the Buddha, the wisdom of Gampopa. So meditate on this. That's why it says here, "… *it becomes a cause for the realization of the equal nature of all phenomena"* — that means emptiness.

4. When you practice this way, step by step, then you see, as I mentioned, the impermanence of every second. Then you divide: past is past, future is future, and you cannot find now something permanent. That itself is emptiness.

5. All this gross that we see, all the dust particles we see: if you divide, investigate through the intellect, it functions within the emptiness. Like, for example, the modern quantum physics theory. The scientists there have now proved, or they've realized, that all these dust particles are nothing but empty. But they don't know how to meditate on them, so they got rid of it: "This is empty, now we cannot do anything. No use."

6. But for us, emptiness is
the best thing we can use:
"Yes, there's nothing that
functions independently;
their nature is emptiness.
There's nothing to attach to,
nothing to hate."
So that understanding
itself is the wisdom.
Through that wisdom,
we get all the excellent
opportunities to purify all the
mental afflictions.

7. Meditate, and that develops
such great love and compassion,
special insight, and it can
really bring peace in the world.
I wish all the great scientists
would realize that —
how to meditate on emptiness —
and bring peace in the world.

8. So we follow that path,
then life is beautiful with a
precious human life. That is
what makes life so precious.
Instead of the center of the
problems, instead of the center
of all the suffering, the life
becomes the center of the peace,
happiness and joy to all others.
This is what is called Dharma
practice, and there you can
practice the bodhicitta.

9. So this big subject
of impermanence,
so many pages we have covered.
Reflect on this,
meditate, relax.
Not just today, as mentioned,
but in your daily life.
In the morning, reflect on
impermanence; meditate on
loving kindness, compassion.
In the evening, reflect on the
bodhicitta; you go to sleep with
the bodhicitta, or with all the
other practices you have.

10. But impermanence!
Don't treat impermanence
as some small thing.
Impermanence is so important,
from the beginning to the end
of your practice.

Milarepa's broken clay pot

From good or bad, we get good teachings

1. I usually repeat this
life story of Milarepa.
He had a clay pot.
He was walking from one place to
another, and his foot stepped on
a piece of rock; he fell down,
and the pot broke into pieces,
unexpectedly.

2. So that amazed Milarepa so much:
"Oh, the pot I had
just one second ago,
now it's in pieces here.
This is all my collection
of the world's wealth."
He doesn't have anything,
only the pot, and that broke.

3. Now, if it had happened to us,
we would cry:
"I'm so unfortunate.
Generally I have nothing,
but now my only pot is broken.
How can I live? There's nothing
I can cook the nettles in."
Oh, we would cry, and then we
are just outraged.

4. But Milarepa was so
appreciative, rejoicing in
the profound teaching that he
received from this: "All the
wealth that I have, the pot,
is now broken into pieces.
This becomes such a profound,
great teacher who gave me
this profound teaching:
everything is impermanent,
especially this precious
human life."

5. Before that, he had the sense,
"This is my pot," in his hand.
When it broke, that sense
in the mind disappeared;
he released that attachment.
The small attachment that
Milarepa had totally vanished in
that instant, and he received
such a profound teaching.
And that became such a powerful
teacher.

6. So we can all get lessons:
from good or bad,
we get good teachings like this.
So we can sustain our practice
by reflecting on impermanence.
We can appreciate
whatever we have through
reflecting on impermanence.
This precious human life that
we have, every day we can
utilize it in the best way,
not wasting it.

7. Whether you are walking,
whether you are eating, whether
you are sleeping, any time,
reflect on impermanence.
Then we can practice the Dharma
— so precious.

8. So now, thank you, thank you
everybody, thank you so much.
Tomorrow we'll reflect
on suffering and karma,
cause and effect.
Now please take a deep breath,
and then say some dedication
prayer.